



Rolling out the red carpet Chelsea Pensioners John, 76, and David, 75 — tour leaders for this week's Chelsea History Festival — in the Royal Hospital's Wren Chapel

# Why letting your mind wander can be the smartest move of all

Rhys Blakely Science Editor

More than 300 years ago, the philosopher John Locke described how ideas sometimes seem to “float in our mind” of their own accord, without being summoned or steered. The French, he noted, called it “reverie”.

These days, reverie has competition. A queue, a bus ride, a moment waiting for a friend: all are more likely to be spent scrolling on a phone.

Now psychologists are beginning to wonder whether this is crowding out a valuable and largely unappreciated experience: that of zoning out.

A new report by Shivang Shelat and Jonathan Schooler of the University of California, Santa Barbara, surveyed 13 years of research on mind wandering, moments when one's thoughts become unshackled from nearby concerns.

One view has been to see such episodes as wasteful, or even dangerous,

lapses of attention. But the evidence hints at something more interesting: the daydreaming mind is often doing useful work.

One example is memory consolidation. Allowing the mind to wander can, studies suggest, help strengthen memories especially when thoughts return to recently learnt material.

Another involves “statistical learning”, a term psychologists use for the brain's ability to detect patterns in messy streams of information. A music lover may, for instance, acquire a feel for where an unfamiliar melody is likely to go next.

Recent work suggests that when the mind wanders, people become better at absorbing the underlying structures that make such predictions possible. It follows that being present in the moment may not be the unalloyed virtue the wellness industry sometimes suggests. Zoning out may also save us from

wasting mental effort on tasks that do not really require it. In one experiment, people were asked to choose a poster to hang on a wall. Some were told to deliberate carefully, while others were instructed to let their minds wander until one option stood out.

The wanderers ended up just as satisfied with their choices as the deliberators. They had simply spent less effort getting there.

Shelat stressed that zoning out is not always the right tactic; it may not be the best way to choose a mortgage or a prime minister. “My gut tells me that bigger decisions are often worth the time, effort and deliberation,” he said.

Mind wandering is not always wise or healthy, he added: “Its downsides depend mainly on two things. First, does it conflict with something else you're trying to focus on? If so, it might lead to more mistakes.

“Second, is the mind going to dark

and ruminative places? If so, it might increase your negative emotions as you grapple with your thoughts. In my opinion, mind wandering is most useful when it happens at opportune moments like when on a walk, and when it feels in our control.”

The problem, Shelat believes, is that modern life leaves less room for mind wandering. “Beneficial brain states or thoughts might never be allowed to emerge if we're constantly fixated on our phones,” he said.

“A common occurrence is to go on your phone and jump from app to app in an eternal search for stimulation. I think this has usurped mind wandering, and any benefits of mind wandering along with it.

“Learning to be bored and to wonder deeply about things will, for many people, be a worthy quest. In my view, it starts with getting off of our phones. We need to bring mind wandering back.”

## Biggest victims of pension fraud lost over £400k

Jessica Sharkey Crime Correspondent

The two biggest victims of pension fraud in England and Wales last year lost more than £400,000 each, according to police figures.

Total pension fraud reported to the City of London police in the last financial year amounted to £77m in 242 cases. Nineteen pension savers suffered individual losses exceeding £100,000.

Savers who have already accessed

their pensions were the primary target, accounting for 166 reports or 69 per cent of all cases. Fraudsters target this group by impersonating bank or pension staff to redirect funds, peddling fake high-yield investments, or using romance scams. Another 76 reports (31 per cent) involved scams in which fraudsters promised to release money for a fee before savers reached the minimum age of 55, not disclosing the taxes imposed by HM Revenue & Customs.

HMRC applies a flat-rate income tax charge of 40 per cent to those withdrawals, which are classed as unauthorised, plus a 15 per cent surcharge if the sum reaches a quarter of the pot. When the scammer's fees are added to the tax charges, the pension saver is often left with nothing.

Zurab Kotaria, chief executive of Identomat, a financial services compliance provider that obtained the data, said: “Gone are the days when a

few security questions were sufficient to beat the scammer. Pension providers and banks need to rethink their approach and start verifying the person, not their password. Accelerating the use of biometric liveness scans, which examine facial expressions, can catch scammers cold.”

The threat is amplified by artificial intelligence, which allows fraudsters to draft convincing emails and mimic voices, writing styles and video calls.

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1 Close and reopen one's eyes (5)

2 Short trip (6)

3 Strongly urge, implore (6)

4 Royal residence (6)

5 Ian Fleming character (5,4)

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| A | A | A | B | B | C | D | E |
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Solutions see T2 MindGames p15  
Cryptic clues T2 MindGames p14

### River Wear teen deaths

A teenager was arrested after a car went into River Wear in Sunderland yesterday, killing two teenage boys and a teenage girl, Northumbria police said. A boy, 17, was arrested in connection with the incident and remains in police custody. Police received reports of a black Audi A3 car coming off the road at Panns Bank and entering the water.

### Ex-champion Dott jailed

Graeme Dott, the former snooker champion, has been jailed for seven years for subjecting a girl and a boy to multiple incidents of sexual abuse. The girl was targeted between 1993 and 1996 and the boy from 2006 to 2010. In both cases, the abuse included penetrative sexual activity. Dott, 49, won the World Snooker Championship in 2006.

### Appeal over baby's body

Police are appealing for the mother of a newborn baby whose body was found on a beach in Bangor, north Wales, to come forward. Detective Sergeant Kelly Wynne, of North Wales police, said the mother was potentially “extremely vulnerable”. The baby was found by a member of the public on Sunday. A post-mortem examination will take place today.

### Skipper ropes in £11,000

A man skipped nearly 1,000 miles across Britain, the equivalent of 40 marathons, in 40 days, raising more than £11,000 for 52 Lives and the School of Kindness charities. Armed with a skipping rope, Krish Patel, 34, from Bolton, set off from Land's End on August 18 and reached John o' Groat's on September 26. He spent up to ten hours skipping each day.

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